In fact, Rotman's remark about "a war of religion" isn't as farfetched as it looks. The great scholar of Jewish mysticism Gershom Scholem repeatedly posed to his listeners and readers the following question: "Can Jewish history manage to re-enter concrete reality without being destroyed by the messianic claim which [that re-entry is bound to] bring up from the depths." The religious fanatics of our day are, of course, those who incite the sort of "war of religion" mentioned by Rotman, and it is a kind of debased messianic urge that pushes them on, and him among them.

As may be remembered, I have wondered several times whether there was something of this messianic urge in Zionism and my answer was negative regarding all the decades stretching from the Congress of Basel in 1897 to the beginning of Begin's premiership in 1977. I was right, on the face of it, but wrong regarding the undercurrents. Well, I know better now. The fascist-like dimension that surfaced in Gush Emunim after the Yom Kippur War—and that my friend Uri Tal grasped so well—should have opened my eyes, but it did not, for the simple reason that the superficial aspect of Israeli life did not look different, notwithstanding all the political crises.

It could be that my stemming from a totally assimilated family and my passage through Catholicism made me particularly blind to those religious undercurrents. My Swedish uncle Hans, the anthroposoph, was repelled by what he considered the militant nationalism of the Zionists during his visit to Palestine in the 1930s. This nationalism expressed itself in fierce anti-Arab policies, such as pushing Arabs out of the labor market and considering how to get rid of an excess of Arab population in the future Jewish state. This nationalist enthusiasm may have been necessary for the creation of the state and its immediate survival but became dangerous once it mixed with religious messianism. What may have been necessary for the creation of the State of Israel could be deadly for its survival. Will an attack from the outside save the Jewish state before internal turmoil destroys it?